when one considers the state of affairs in Travancore at the start of the nineteenth century.

A key factor in kick-starting this great change was the spread of education among the Christian communities of Travancore and Cochin. According to the 2011 Census almost 88 per cent of the present population of Tamil Nadu are Hindu, with Christians and Muslims virtually neck and neck at 6 per cent each – whereas next door in Kerala nearly some 24 per cent of the population are Christians. The success of this combination of Christian conversion and education inevitably spilled over into the wider community, leading some members of the Hindu majority to ask questions of themselves, exemplified by the rise of the phenomenon that became Ayyavazhi, or ‘path of the father’: a religious cult built around a mystic who saw himself as a reincarnation of Lord Vishnu, and which today has an estimated ten million followers in South India.

Its creator was a frail young man popularly known as Ayya Vaikundar, born to a Nadar or Channar couple in Kanyakumari District in about 1810. Many stories are told about this remarkable young man. He was said to have walked in the sea and disappeared and then returned to life, and after a six-year period of extreme self-mortification to have acquired powers that enabled him to banish evil spirits. He preached that he had come to bring the present Kali Yuga or ‘dark age’ to an end, together with all its injustices, after which he would rule as a Dharma Raja. His fast-growing popularity with the masses led to his imprisonment by the Travancore Raj in about 1839 on the grounds that he was disturbing the social order, although he appears to have been released without charge. Vaikundar’s abiding message was that the Kali Yuga could be brought to an end if people lived with dignity and self-respect. This fired the imagination of Travancore’s oppressed underclasses and explains why he remains such an inspirational figure among the common folk to this day.